

What makes a good chairperson?

Worksheet

- A** Work individually. Imagine you are the chairperson in each situation below. What would your response be? Number your first and second choice each time.
- B** Have a meeting to reach a group decision on the best and second best response for each situation. Change the role of chairperson after every two items:
And now I'm going to hand over the chair to ...

- 1 You are expecting ten participants for a 9.00 am meeting. It is 9.02 and only eight people are present. The two missing people are not key participants. No one told you of any plans to be late.
 - a Begin the meeting with those present.
 - b Call the two people on their mobile phones to see if they are coming.
 - c Wait another few minutes and then begin.
- 2 The meeting has been running for 25 minutes. Some participants have not spoken, although they appear to be interested and attentive.
 - a Do nothing at the moment, but continue to monitor the situation.
 - b Ask one of the non-contributors for an opinion or reaction.
 - c Ask the non-contributors in a friendly way why they are not speaking.
- 3 As chairperson, you have introduced a topic. However, no-one wants to begin the discussion.
 - a Ask a general question to the group.
 - b Ask a general question to one person.
 - c Ask an easy, specific question to one person.
- 4 The meeting has been running for 45 minutes and half the agenda items have been covered. You notice, through non-verbal behaviour, that the interest level of the group is falling.
 - a Say you will shorten the meeting, then finish the current item and close the meeting.
 - b Suggest a five-minute break.
 - c Speak more loudly and in a more lively way.
- 5 One participant starts talking for a long time about a topic that is not on the agenda.
 - a Say in a friendly way *I feel this is a bit of a side-track*, then refocus the discussion.
 - b Thank the participant and suggest you discuss the topic at the next meeting.
 - c Thank the participant and suggest you discuss the topic at the end of the meeting if there is time.
- 6 Two people, sitting together, keep whispering to each other. It has been going on for some time.
 - a Ask them to share their discussion with the group.
 - b Ask one of them a specific question to refocus their attention.
 - c Pause at an appropriate point while you are talking and look at them. Wait until they stop.

